hostages and salvaging Britain's military reputation, Ellenborough began looking for a way to reverse his position.

While he waited for Ellenborough to let him off his leash, Pollock kept himself busy revenging himself on those Afghans within his reach. He sent out punitive parties to cow the tribes of the Jalalabad valley, 'unroofing a few villages . . . and burning everything combustible'.[15] One brigade was sent south into the Shinwari country, to burn all the forts and villages and fell the trees. One day alone, thirty-five forts were set ablaze. Another brigade under the artilleryman Augustus Abbott was sent towards Gandamak to punish the villagers who had massacred the last survivors of the 44th Foot. 'We destroyed all the vineyards,' he later recorded, 'and cut deep rings around trees of two centuries' growth.[ll] Their forts and houses were destroyed; their walls blown up and their beautiful trees left to perish. The retribution was thorough and enduring in its effects. It is lamentable to see the mischief done, but the example was quite necessary.'[16]

MacGregor, the Political Officer with the force, also wrote approvingly of the brutality and destruction, saying that while demolished walls could soon be repaired, the destruction of trees – 'a measure which might at first seem barbarous to the civilised mind' – was the only way for the Afghans to be made to 'feel the weight of our power, for they delight in the shade of their trees'. In any village believed to have aided Akbar Khan, orders were given 'at once to commence the work of destruction so that neither fort, house, tree, grain nor boosa [fodder] should be spared them'.[17]

Meanwhile, the onset of the summer heat, and with it disease, added to the frustration of the troops left waiting in Jalalabad. 'Great was the disappointment among the officers,' wrote Lieutenant Greenwood,

> and loud the murmurings among the men, when at first days then weeks passed away while we remained inactive . . . The camels and baggage animals were dying in numbers daily, and the stench of their dead bodies and the filth of the immense camp was insupportable. Millions of flies were bred in the masses of corruption that lay on every side. The very air was black with them, and such torments they became, that it was almost impossible to get a minute's rest. Provisions were bad and scarce. Sickness began to rage among the men, who bitterly complained that they were brought there to die like cowards in that pest house, instead of being led at once against the enemy.[18]

Temperatures soon rose to forty-three degrees Celsius, and many of the officers disappeared into the underground cool houses, or tykhanas, that they found in the basements of the old houses.